Innovatr Insights Report

Protein Over Principle

How Veganism Lost Its Edge and What the Rise of Protein Reveals About Modern Consumers

South Africa, 2025

Insights that drive results

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Executive Summary

For nearly a decade, plant-based eating was shorthand for progress—a moral movement backed by environmental urgency and ethical conviction. Yet by 2025, that cultural glow has dimmed. Innovatr's Health & Wellness Pulse survey of 2,000 South African consumers reveals a fundamental shift: from ideological purity to pragmatic nourishment. What began as veganism's radical momentum has recalibrated into something more human—a search for balance, authenticity, and functional wellness centered on protein.

Key Insight

This is not the death of conscience but the rebirth of common sense. Consumers have not abandoned values; they have reprioritised practicality. Protein's rise symbolizes a desire for strength, satiety, and visible results—benefits that feel tangible in uncertain times. For brands, the opportunity lies in bridging ethics and efficacy, making sustainability feel strong rather than sanctimonious.

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From Ideals to Intake: The Retreat of Moral Eating

Dietary Identity Shift

14% → 7%

2018 2025

of urban South Africans identify as vegan or vegetarian—a 50% decline in dietary ideology despite high environmental awareness.

Source: Innovatr Health & Wellness Pulse Survey, 2025

KEY INSIGHT

Values haven't disappeared—they've been reprioritized. People still care about the planet but practicality now trumps ideology.

84% still agree that "what I eat affects the planet," yet health and affordability outweigh ethics by **3:1** in food choices.

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Key Data: Pragmatism Over Principle

Decision Drivers

3:1

Health and affordability now outweigh ethics by a 3:1 margin when respondents explain why they choose or reject plant-based foods.

Source: Innovatr Health & Wellness Pulse Survey, 2025

KEY INSIGHT

Economic pressure and fatigue with performative consumption have shifted priorities from moral absolutism to practical nourishment.

"I still care about the environment, but I also need energy to get through a ten-hour day. Tofu just doesn't do it for me."

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The Backlash Against Processed "Plants"

Ingredient Anxiety

56%

of South Africans now describe most plant-based products as "too processed"

↑ Up from 29% in 2021

Source: Innovatr Health & Wellness Pulse 2025

KEY INSIGHT

The narrative of purity that once powered veganism has been undercut by perceptions of artificiality and ultra-processing.

"Long ingredient lists rank as the number-one deterrent to purchase, even among committed flexitarians."

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The Protein Renaissance

Protein Mentions

+42%

surge in mentions of 'high-protein' as a desirable attribute since 2020, overtaking 'low-fat' and 'sugar-free' for the first time.

Source: Innovatr Health & Wellness Pulse Survey

KEY INSIGHT

Protein bridges wellness and realism —consumers link it to strength, satiety and tangible results versus abstract sustainability promises.

Protein straddles the divide between wellness and practicality. It feeds muscles but also signals a desire for strength, agency and stability in uncertain times.

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Key Data: The Protein Premium

Natural Protein Preference

68%

agree that protein from natural sources is better than plant substitutes

Source: Innovatr Health & Wellness Pulse Survey 2025

KEY INSIGHT

Consumers are moving away from ultra-processed alternatives toward authentic, minimally processed protein sources like eggs, yogurt, and chicken.

Protein-rich categories such as Greek yogurt, eggs, minimally processed meats, and biltong show double-digit year-on-year growth in stated consumption.

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Flexitarianism: The Middle Ground Becomes Mainstream

Dietary Balance

64%

of South African consumers report reducing but not eliminating meat from their diets.

↑ Up from 47% in 2023

Source: Innovatr Health & Wellness Pulse Survey, 2025

KEY INSIGHT

Flexitarianism has quietly grown into the mainstream approach, replacing absolutism with intentional moderation and balance.

"It's not about quitting meat. It's about earning it—making conscious choices about when and how much to consume."

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The Evolution of Conscious Eating

Vegan Absolutism

Moral purity through total elimination of all animal products and unwavering ethical commitment

"True sustainability requires complete rejection of animal exploitation. Any compromise undermines the movement's moral foundation."

VS

Flexitarian Pragmatism

Balanced, intentional consumption with occasional meat, mindful moderation, and sustainable habits

"It's not about quitting meat—it's about earning it. Progress over perfection creates lasting change that works for my body and the planet."

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Health Reframed: From Restriction to Resilience

Wellness Priorities

74%

define "healthy eating" as "energy and feeling good" rather than restriction or avoidance.

18%

Only 18% prioritize avoiding "bad" foods as their definition of healthy eating.

Source: Innovatr Health & Wellness Pulse 2025

KEY INSIGHT

The wellness conversation has shifted from deprivation to empowerment. Consumers now celebrate strength, immunity, and mental balance over rigid dietary rules.

"The pandemic years re-wired priorities. Resilience replaced perfection as the goal, transforming how we define what it means to eat well."

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Authenticity as the New Currency

Brand Trust Premium

+18

point trust premium for products perceived as "authentic and minimally marketed" over those labeled "eco-friendly" or "vegan"

Source: Innovatr Brand Trust Index 2025

KEY INSIGHT

Consumers now demand proof, not promises. Transparency and provenance outweigh virtue signaling in building lasting brand loyalty.

"Local dairy and meat brands leveraging farm names, traceability, and small-batch narratives rebuild credibility where generic 'plant-based' claims have lost their power."

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Strategic Implications for Brands

How to win with protein-first, pragmatic consumers

Substance over Signal

Green leaves on packaging no longer guarantee appeal. Consumers interrogate ingredient panels and functional claims. Demonstrate tangible benefits through performance, taste, and texture rather than declaring virtue.

Function with Feeling

Link protein to confidence, endurance, and everyday strength. Marketing that connects protein to emotional benefits resonates more than clinical nutrition copy. "Fuel for a Stronger Day" outperforms generic health claims.

Realism as Aspiration

Consumers admire discipline but reject dogma. Campaigns celebrating "progress, not perfection" deliver higher emotional engagement. Position health as inclusive, acknowledging imperfection while providing credible tools for better choices.

Redefining Sustainability

The next chapter of conscious consumption reconnects ethics to efficacy. Brands that help consumers live well—physically, mentally, and socially—earn longer-term loyalty than those that moralise. Balance human and planetary wellbeing.

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Consumer Segments: Who's Eating What?

31%

Functional Fuelers

- Pursue energy, recovery and performance
- Link food to strength and tangible results
- Focus on functional benefits over ethical concerns
- High-protein products are essential daily choices

44%

Balanced Realists

- Aim for moderation—"a bit of everything, nothing extreme"
- Want products that work for body and planet—if possible
- Value practicality over perfectionism
- Flexitarian approach: reduce meat but don't eliminate

25%

Ethical Eaters

- Still prioritize moral and ecological motives
- Environmental impact drives food choices
- Animal welfare remains a key consideration
- Shrinking segment but still vocal and influential

The Shift in Consumer Priorities

Balanced Realists now dominate both spend and influence, favoring products that deliver practical benefits alongside ethical considerations. This pragmatic middle ground represents the new mainstream, replacing the ideological extremes that once defined the wellness conversation.

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Lessons from the Protein Pivot

LESSON 01

Trends fade; tensions endure

The tension between ethics and enjoyment, progress and practicality, is eternal. Successful brands manage it, not moralise it.

LESSON 02

Health is holistic

Consumers integrate food with mood, movement and identity. Protein fits because it bridges body and mind—it's science with soul.

LESSON 03

Authenticity scales better than ideology

Movements fracture; trust compounds. The most resilient propositions are those grounded in truth, not trend.

LESSON 04

Local relevance beats imported rhetoric

South African consumers prize affordability and accessibility as much as ethics. Global vegan narratives built in Silicon Valley rarely translate without cultural context.

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The Road Ahead: 2027 Predictions

Three converging currents reshaping the protein and wellness landscape

Blended Innovation

Hybrid products mixing plant and animal proteins for optimal nutrition and environmental footprint. The future is not either-or, but thoughtful combination.

Transparent Processing

Clear labelling of production methods such as cold-pressed, fermented, and air-dried will replace vague health claims. Consumers demand to know exactly how their food is made.

Holistic Positioning

Brands moving beyond diet into lifestyle ecosystems encompassing sleep, stress management, movement, and community connection. Health is multidimensional.

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Conclusion: From Hype to Health

> **The decline of vegan absolutism and the ascent of protein are not opposites but chapters in the same story: society's ongoing negotiation between ideals and realities.**

For Consumers

Rediscovering food that is real, functional, and forgiving

For Brands

Proving value through authenticity, transparency, and tangible benefits

For Culture

Maturity in understanding that sustainability must start with the self

> ***Veganism may have lost its edge, but purpose has not. It has simply been refuelled by protein.***

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Innovatr Expertise

Consumer Research

Our proprietary methodologies uncover the deep motivations behind consumer behavior, delivering insights that traditional research misses. From dietary shifts to wellness trends, we track what matters.

Strategic Workshops

Interactive sessions that transform data into actionable strategies, tailored to your brand's unique challenges in the evolving health and nutrition landscape.

Trend Analysis

We contextualize South African consumer behaviors within global trends—from plant-based movements to protein premiums—helping you anticipate shifts before your competitors.

Health & Wellness Expertise

Specialized knowledge in FMCG, nutrition, and wellness categories with deep understanding of how South Africans balance ethics, health, and affordability in their food choices.

> At Innovatr, we connect brands directly to what South Africans want—practically and emotionally—in the moments that matter. Our insights don't just inform; they inspire action and drive measurable results.

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Action & Next Steps

Explore Protein Trends in Your Category

Discover how the shift from plant-based absolutism to protein pragmatism affects your specific product portfolio with tailored consumer insights.

Book a Strategic Workshop

Join our hands-on workshop to translate these health and wellness insights into actionable strategies for positioning authentic, functional products.

Commission Deeper Research

Want to understand Functional Fuelers, Balanced Realists, or Ethical Eaters in your market? Let's design custom research to answer your most pressing questions.

Ready to help your brand navigate the protein renaissance with authenticity and insight?

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